Afterword

God's Teeth came from a lot of places.

Much of it was born from my work in American public education. During all the active shooter drills, maybe. Or the training sessions by Family Services, where they taught us to look for the signs of the unspeakable in children terrified into silence.

I taught English for over a decade. The cries for help came smuggled inside short stories and poems and essays. I found parts of this thing there and stitched them together. Read the collective nightmares of enough children, it's hard not to personify the monster that keeps coming back. The "who" stops mattering. The names of those responsible for fantastic, unforgettable crimes fade. Cousin, sibling, father, mother, it becomes less and less surprising. You start to read them all as the same Beast.

Then there are stories passed down the trenches. The ones educators aren't supposed to tell. The ones that force themselves out anyway. Anonymized and spilled out like bile over a therapist, colleague, or spouse. Secondhand trauma bonding, passed around the teacher's lounge like the last cigarette.

I did additional research, unable to look away. The juvenile correctional facilities, the boys' homes, police raids. The shit you couldn't imagine doing to anyone, not to mention a baby. The stories that make you thankful you weren't the mandated reporter on duty that day.

Of course, I also had to talk about all the ways those reports can fail. The ways the state can sometimes make it worse. Sloppy allegations and inevitable reprisals. Ferrying victims between one abuser's lair to the next within the foster system. "Bus therapy." Snatching kids from the streets to fill quotas in private prisons or troubled-teen camps.

Regrettably, Trump had his say in the content. In time, all those difficult questions the conservatives fear to answer make their way to teachers. I had to explain the kids in cages to young boys and girls who looked just like them. I couldn't parrot the lies my state legislature demanded, so I had to stand in front of innocents and tell the truth every day: The cages are nothing new. They are as old as America, descended from the slave block and the prison system. This is the inheritance of Empire…at least until the world boils.

The pandemic. Dead teachers. Dead families. Missing students. Enough to keep a head spinning, even before tallying the dizzying statistics. A "9/11" becomes a unit of measurement. They start adding up with the regularity of a metronome.

Not that all of the students believe in 9/11. Some of their parents have "corrected" them. They often screamed about such "conspiracies" during conferences. In person. Unmasked. Spittle flying into my face.

And who can forget the realization that your portion of this pain is counterfeit? No matter how real it may feel, it pales in comparison. It's *nothing* compared to the real suffering that inspires all this quaint compassion fatigue. Nothing compared too what a nurse or social worker may go through in a single day. The cold comfort that someone else is suffering more. That feeling of being disgraced and mocked by your own empathy…I tried to put that in here, as well.

God's Teeth came from a lot of places. Too many places.

Like everyone, I can only process so much. The brain is eager to turn horrors too numerous to count into something easier to grasp. Something monolithic and god-like. Sufferings weigh down on the mind until it compresses the myriad horrors into a singular, terrible One. Variables become the constant. Exceptions solidify into law. Chaos grows patterns and becomes construct.

This book started in a lot of places. It coalesced at the edges of my vision, beneath and between. A malevolent intellect behind every violation. An entity immutable. An inescapable savagery, reproduced by life itself.

This book is an attempt to write the poison out of my body. To give it a name. To make it a fiction.

I hope it works.

I hope such a god isn't real.

Caleb Stokes
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